

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6NT

Declarer: East

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 9 5
♥ J 4
♦ K 10 8 2
♣ J 7 3

♠ 8 4

♥ A 8 7 2

♦ A 9 6 4

♣ A K Q

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10

♥ K Q 10 9

♦ Q J 5 3

♣ 9 5 4 2

♠ A K 7 6 3 2

♥ 6 5 3

♦ 7

♣ 10 8 6

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North

as long as they split 3-2 you will succeed. So you play ♠A, ♠K; East follows to the first and discards a ♦ on the second.

OK, West has two trump tricks, but don't give up. Maybe, just maybe, there is a way out. Check your winners: You have won 3 tricks - ♥A and ♠A K. You have 4 more top winners - ♦A and ♣A K Q. If you can somehow add 3 more small trumps that will be the 10 you need.

Play dummy's ♦7 to your ♦A, then ruff a ♦. Play a ♣ to your hand and ruff another ♦. Play another ♣ to your hand and ruff your last ♦. While you are ruffing these three ♦s West is helplessly following suit.

Now play to your good ♣ while West again has to follow suit.

You have taken the first 10 tricks. Poor West is going to end up ruffing his partner's ♦ winner with one of his master trumps.

Trumps don't always split as evenly as you would like them to.

When they split badly, sometimes you can recover by ruffing with small trumps while the trump-heavy defender has to follow suit.

This is called "trump elopement".

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠.
Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠.
Partner now bids 3♠.

You wouldn't have chosen ♠s for a trump suit.

But you aren't doing the choosing, partner is. He has set the trump suit as ♠s and asks that you bid game if you have a maximum 1NT opening. So you bid 4♠, as instructed.

North plays 4♠. East leads ♥K, West plays ♥J. You have no reason to hold up so you win the ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Things look simple. You can afford one ♠ loser so as long as they split 3-2 you will succeed. So you play ♠A, ♠K; East follows to the first and discards a ♦ on the second.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 8 7 6
♥ Q 8 5
♦ A J 2
♣ K Q J 3

♠ 10 9 4 2
♥ J 10 4 3
♦ 5 4
♣ 10 8 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J
♥ A 7 2
♦ K Q 7 6
♣ A 9 4

♠ Q 5 3
♥ K 9 6
♦ 10 9 8 3
♣ 7 6 2

West

North

East

South

2NT

Pass

6NT

All Pass

6NT by East

Why not try both? If you make sure you try them in the right order you can have both chances.

Suppose you lead a small ♠ from dummy and play your ♠J, and it loses to South's ♠Q. If you then try leading a small ♥ toward dummy's ♥Q, obviously the defender with the ♥K will grab it to set the contract.

Instead, try the effect of leading toward the ♥Q first. If South has the ♥K then you will succeed in creating the extra winner you need. But what if you play the ♥Q and North takes it with his ♥K? Too bad, but at least you are not dead yet. You still have a chance to finesse North for the ♠Q.

Here is an important principle. There are two critical cards, the ♠Q and the ♥K. However they are not the same degree of criticality.

If the ♠Q is in a favorable position, (with North), you are always going to make your contract no matter which you try first.

But if only the ♥K is in a favorable position, (with South), you can make the contract only if you try ♥s first.

Sometimes bidding is easy. Partner has 20 or 21 points, balanced. You have 13 points, balanced. Total = 33 or 34 points, balanced. So you close your eyes and bid 6NT.

The contract would be 6NT played by West.

East plays 6NT. South leads the ♦10. Too bad South didn't lead a ♠. Oh, well.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

There is no way to get more than 4 winners in each minor suit, so you need to win either the ♠J or ♥Q.

Which one should you try?